

IN THE BANK West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee with TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee at an Eid gathering in Kolkata, Apr. 11

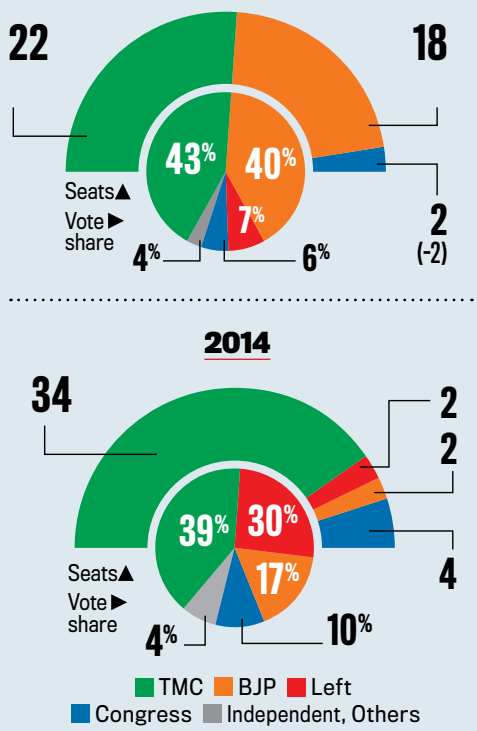
PTI

ROUNDS OF FIRE

The BJP was a fledgling power in 2014. Five years later they gave the TMC a mighty scare

LOK SABHA POLLS

(Total seats: 42)



THE THOUSANDS PACKED INTO THE VENUE—THE SUKANTA SPORTING CLUB GROUND, IN A VILLAGE NOT FAR FROM THE BORDER—SWORE AND SEETHED IMPATIENTLY ON A recent afternoon in Dhubulia, in south-central Bengal's Nadia district. The rallyists gathered in support of Mahua Moitra, the Trinamool Congress candidate for Krishnanagar, were cooking on slow flame in the stifling heat. For hours, the gathering chafed under the intense discomfort, calling for water and fighting for a place in front of the pedestal fans. Then, a mechanical rumble issued from the sky, as the helicopter carrying Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee hove into view. That's all it took for the crowd to revive itself. The emergence of Mamata's familiar figure, in her trademark blue-bordered white sari, drew hysteric cheers. In Bengal, scenes like this have played out at the CM's rallies for over a decade now. However, in the past three years, the BJP, Bengal's principal Opposition party, has projected her former protégé Suvendu Adhikari—who defected to the saffron camp in 2020 and defeated Mamata in the 2021 assembly polls from Nandigram—as a counter. No other Opposition leader is as popular as Adhikari, and outpourings of mass affection are now a rally staple for him too.

The bruising rivalry between the ruling TMC and the BJP, never very civil, truly boils over during election time. The BJP won an unexpectedly high 18 seats out of a total 42 in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, up from two in 2014, still only stirring itself up from the embryonic state it was in at the turn of the century. The reasons that fuelled this saffron rise, amidst a concomitant